

DecisionBrief — Conversation Transcript

Scenario: restaurant-pos • 2 Fast-Casual Taco Shops • \$1.2M • 1,800 tickets/week • Square + Tablets

2026-05-14 01:22 PM

DecisionBrief: Evaluating a restaurant POS? Tell me about your restaurant and your role?

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You: I own two fast-casual taco shops in Austin — one on South Lamar open 3 years, one on Burnet opened 11 months ago. 35 employees total. I handle ops, my wife does marketing. We're doing \$1.2M a year combined but margins are slipping.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — 2 locations, fast-casual tacos, \$1.2M combined, 35 staff. What POS do you use today and what's triggering the change?

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You: Square POS on iPads since day one, plus DoorDash tablet, Uber Eats tablet, and handwritten kitchen tickets. No inventory tracking — we eyeball. Last month we had \$8k food cost variance, staff giving free food to friends, and we double-entered online orders. Labor is 38% and I can't tell if it's scheduling or theft. Square reports don't show per-location profit after food cost.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — Square + 2 delivery tablets + paper kitchen, no inventory, \$8k food variance, comp theft, 38% labor, no per-location true profit. What does a typical week look like volume-wise?

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You: About 1,800 tickets a week across both, 40% takeout, 25% delivery through DoorDash/Uber, 35% dine-in. Average ticket \$14.50. Lunch rush 11-2 is 60% of sales. We have 6 line cooks, 12 front. Inventory is done Sunday night by me counting boxes — no depletion tracking. We 86 items mid-shift and don't know until cook yells.

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DecisionBrief: Clear — 1,800 tickets/week, 40% takeout 25% delivery 35% dine-in, \$14.50 avg, lunch-heavy. Manual inventory Sundays, 86s mid-shift. What have you tried before for POS or restaurant systems?

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You: We tried MarketMan for inventory 6 months ago — staff wouldn't log waste, too many steps. Tried Toast demo last year but it was \$600/mo per location plus hardware and they wanted 3-year contract. We stuck with Square because it's cheap \$0 monthly but we're paying in other ways. My manager likes Clover but I worry it's just Square with different logo.

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DecisionBrief: Got it — MarketMan failed on staff adoption, Toast felt expensive \$600/location + 3-year lock, Square feels cheap but costing you in food variance and labor. What must a new POS actually do to be worth switching?

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You: Must unify DoorDash/Uber into one KDS — no more three tablets. Real inventory depletion linked to recipes so when we sell 10 carnitas tacos it deducts pork and tortillas. Labor scheduling with clock-in and sales integration so I see labor % live. And staff permissions — no more voiding without manager PIN. Need offline mode — South Lamar internet dropped 4 hours last month and we lost sales. And per-location P&L; after food cost in one dashboard.

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DecisionBrief: Clear — unified delivery into KDS, recipe-level inventory depletion, live labor % with scheduling and clock-in, manager PIN for voids/comps, offline mode, per-location P&L; after food cost. What constraints or budget?

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You: Budget under \$500/mo total for both locations including software and payments — Square payments are 2.6% now, if new system is 2.9% that kills me on \$1.2M. Must work with existing iPads or low-cost hardware under \$2k total. Need to migrate in July slow month, can't switch during SXSW or ACL. And my staff is mostly Spanish-speaking, need Spanish UI for KDS and training that isn't just YouTube videos.

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DecisionBrief: Understood — under \$500/mo both locations including software + payments, keep payment rate near 2.6%, hardware under \$2k total, migrate July not SXSW/ACL, Spanish UI for KDS and hands-on training. What worries you most?

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You: Staff turnover — I train someone on POS and they quit in 2 weeks. Also switching costs — if KDS goes down during lunch rush we are dead, 60% of sales in 3 hours. And if inventory tracking adds steps, cooks will ignore it like they did MarketMan. And my biggest fear: I pick Toast or Clover and it's just expensive Square with same food variance and I still don't know if it's theft or waste.

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DecisionBrief: Thanks — turnover and training churn, KDS reliability during lunch rush, inventory adoption risk, and paying more for same problems are key. If this works, what does success look like in 6 months?

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You: One dashboard for both shops showing real profit after food and labor, not just sales. Food cost variance from \$8k to under \$1.5k because depletion and waste tracked, comps need manager PIN so theft down. DoorDash/Uber in one KDS no more tablets. Labor from 38% to 31% because scheduling tied to sales. And I can work 50 hours not 75 because I don't count boxes Sunday night.

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DecisionBrief: I have enough information to prepare your Decision Brief.